

LX-002

The Non-NLU Student's Guide to Getting Top Firm Internships

Audience: Students | Stage: Before You Apply | Read Time: 8 min

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01

Reframing the disadvantage

Let's be honest: NLU graduates have a structural advantage. Brand recognition, alumni networks, and on-campus recruitment give them a head start. But here's what most non-NLU students don't realise — firms care far more about what you can do than where you studied.

The partners making hiring decisions at Tier 1 firms didn't all go to NLUs themselves. Many came from state universities and regional law colleges. They know that college name doesn't equal competence. What they're really filtering for is: Can this person write? Can they research? Will they show up on time and do the work?

Your disadvantage is real, but it's smaller than you think. The gap isn't ability — it's access and awareness. This guide is about closing that gap.

02

What firms actually look for

Talk to any senior associate at a top firm and they'll tell you the same thing: they'd rather have an intern who writes well and works hard than one with a fancy college name who can't draft a basic email.

The top qualities firms evaluate are: writing ability (can you draft a clear, concise legal opinion?), research skills (can you find relevant case law and statutes efficiently?), reliability (do you meet deadlines without being chased?), and initiative (do you ask intelligent questions and volunteer for work?).

None of these are taught exclusively at NLUs. You can develop every single one of them through deliberate practice — mooting, writing for law journals, taking online courses, and doing internships at smaller firms to build your foundation.

03

Building your portfolio

Before you apply to top firms, build evidence that you can do the work. Start with 2-3 internships at smaller firms or district courts — these are easier to get and teach you practical skills that classroom learning never will.

Write. Publish articles on SCC Online, LiveLaw, or even a personal blog. Having 3-4 published pieces on legal topics shows you can research and articulate arguments. Enter moot court competitions — even if you don't win, the experience of drafting memorials and arguing is invaluable.

Create a portfolio document: a one-page summary of your internships, publications, moots, and any relevant certifications. This becomes your proof that college name aside, you've put in the work.

04

Direct application strategy

Without campus placements, you need to create your own opportunities. Here's the systematic approach that works:

Make a list of 30-40 target firms. Include Tier 1 firms (your stretch targets), Tier 2 firms (realistic targets), and boutique/specialised firms (where your specific interests give you an edge). Research each firm: know their practice areas, recent matters, and key people.

Send personalised cold emails (see LX-001) to 5-7 firms per week. Track every application in a spreadsheet — firm name, contact person, date sent, follow-up date, response. Apply to firms that post on job portals like Superlawyer, LawCtopus, and LinkedIn simultaneously.

The numbers game matters. If your response rate is 10% (which is good for cold emails), you need to send at least 30-40 emails to land 3-4 interviews.

05

Making it stick

Once you get an internship at a good firm, your job is to make them forget which college you came from. Show up early, stay late when needed, and deliver work before the deadline.

Ask for feedback proactively. At the end of each week, ask your supervising associate: "Is there anything I could have done differently this week?" This shows maturity and a genuine desire to improve — qualities that stand out regardless of your college.

Build relationships, not just line items on your CV. Stay in touch with the associates and partners you work with. A genuine connection at one firm can open doors to three others through referrals. The legal community in India is smaller than you think — your reputation travels.